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Rebecca Kilgore

Vocalist Rebecca Kilgore was born in Waltham, Massachusetts. Although her father was a schooled musician and composer, Rebecca describes herself as a "closet" singer/guitarist during high school and she had no aspirations to a career as a professional musician. She moved to Portland in 1979 and began singing with local musicians, most often with the Wholly Cats, a local swing band. The Portland surroundings provided diverse musical influences and Rebecca sang in Western swing, country and Django-derived jazz groups. In the early '90s she began a fruitful relationship with pianist/songwriter Dave Frishberg. She is currently enjoying a productive association with Arbors Records and their roster of fine band leaders and arrangers. Rebecca works regularly in the Portland area and is becoming a familiar voice at jazz parties and festivals across the country.

Rebecca was interviewed on September 13, 1997 at the Allegheny Jazz Party in Chautauqua, NY by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We're interviewing today in Chautauqua, New York and it's a great pleasure for me to have vocalist and guitarist Rebecca Kilgore joining us. Pleased to meet you — in front of the cameras.

RK: Good to meet you in front of the cameras too.

MR: So what did you want to sing for us today?

RK: I don't want to sing anything.

MR: I know. That was a nasty way to start. I told you I was going to be nice and I am. When you were, let's say 15, did you ever think that you would be making a career as a musician?

RK: You know, not up until I started making a career as a musician at age 30 did I ever think that I would make a career as a musician. It was a complete surprise to me. Because I was very shy and I used to sing in my car and in my living room, but the thought of singing in front of people was mortifying. So when it happened it just —

MR: So you weren't one of those kind of high school people that everyone knew as — oh she's the musician, she's the singer, she gets the lead in the plays.

RK: No, gosh, I was a closet musician. I always marvel at these people who know from an early age, just always knew they wanted to sing or whatever, and they just pursued that goal all their lives.

MR: But some of them don't make it.

RK: Some of them don't make it, but the ones that do say that that was the reason I guess. But I've never been that focused. I've always loved music on the side.

MR: Why the music of the '30s and '40s?

RK: I don't know. It's the music that speaks to me. I love melodies and I guess we tend to romanticize the generation before us. I used to like the clothes and everything from my parents' era. So the music just speaks to me. It's very romantic and kind of naive and simple — but not simple musically, just in the messages that it conveys. It's just always appealed to me because of its beauty.

MR: When you attend these kind of festivals and you look out at the audience, it's almost like you're singing to your parents.

RK: I'm singing their music. And that's good.

MR: It's good — does it concern you and maybe the other musicians that they're not going to be there forever?

RK: Yeah, frankly, to be quite honest, we're worried about our audience dying off. And they are getting older, and I don't know what's going to happen. I mean we may be relegated to really obscure jazz festivals for old people, as we age too. I don't know what's going to happen. I don't see young people — well maybe some — young people appreciating this music. There's a big swing dance furor happening right now. I live in the Pacific Northwest, and there are a lot of swing dances, so swing dance music — live swing dance music — is quite popular, even among younger people. So maybe that's a way that it'll get carried through. I hope.

MR: Did you ever feel that you might have been born in the wrong era?

RK: Yeah. But I'm sure that, as I say, we tend to romanticize eras. I'm sure there were some awful things about it.

MR: Right. And it probably wasn't easy to be, let's say you were the girl singer with the Harry James Band. We may think about — boy that would have been so neat. I always think that I should have been in the saxophone section of one of those bands back then.

RK: It was probably pretty hard though, life on the road, especially as a woman, being the only woman in a group of men traveling day in and day out. I think traveling on a bus, trying to keep your clothes looking nice for when you go on, and you're stuffing them in a suitcase and you don't get to launder them — oh it just must have been very primitive.

MR: Who from that era are favorites of yours? Anybody in particular?

RK: Well my highest ideal is Ella Fitzgerald because she was just everything in a jazz singer, to me. She can sing the melodies straight and make it beautiful and break your heart, and yet she can be very swingy and jazzy and scat sing and improvise. So she just covers it all to my way of thinking. She's a very classy person, she has a classy delivery. There's just no one who can equal her I think. She just does it all. And then other singers that I got into are Anita O'Day, June Christie, Julie London, Doris Day, Chris Connor, Peggy Lee, Maxine Sullivan — it's a long list.

MR: Have you ever thought about doing scat like Ella?

RK: I try it now and then. It's really not my cup of tea. I kind of hack away at it but I feel like an amateur at it and I feel like I'm just more suited to singing the melodies. I'll leave the scat singing to other singers who can do it better.

MR: Now in a situation like this weekend, where unfortunately Dave [Frishberg] wasn't here — and we hope he's all right by the way — was it a little anxious for you to — okay we're re-working the schedule and now you're singing with this, and now you're going to do this and that.

RK: Sure. Because Dave and I have a rapport after having worked together for so long, like five and a half years, and I know a lot of obscure songs. That's kind of what I gravitate to. I don't do a lot of standards, which sometimes is a disadvantage. So he and I do these obscure songs and we kind of have these arrangements worked out, and I thought oh boy, this will be fun to pull out some of our strange material and kind of bring something new and different. And well that's out the window, because a lot of these people, although they know a wide variety of songs, some of them that I know are pretty weird. So I'm having to draw from my more well-known repertoire. And when you're playing with someone that you've never played before with, well how's it going to end, how's it going to begin, what's going to happen in the middle, you know, the whole thing. So it's a little nerve wracking, but you know that's it.

MR: Well I heard you last night. I guess you were singing with Keith [Ingham]. And it got to the end of the tune and you did something that was very musical to do — and I'm not even sure I can describe it, but it just had something to do with when you were going to tag, that you made it obvious, you sang an obvious note so that he knew, okay tag. And then when you got to the very end you just held this note out and let him, and he did kind of his [scats]. But you just held that thing out there, and it sounded like it was planned.

RK: Well I think that a good guide is to keep it as simple as possible. I'm not going to add a whole bunch of embellishments. I'll just kind of keep to a very simple concept and let the pianist fill in the blanks.

MR: Trust that they'll know what you're after.

RK: And they're such great musicians that they do. And I'm glad it sounded like it was rehearsed.

MR: You got pretty high praise from a drummer that I know that you know very well, and he said that working with you is like having another musician in the band and a co-leader, and that he depends on you a lot because he's stuck behind the drums, that he communicates through you. And he was telling me about some signals you make that —

RK: That would be Hal Smith I imagine.

MR: Yeah.

RK: Yeah we've known each other for a long time although we haven't worked together solidly. I first worked with him in the early '80s in Portland, Oregon. He was in a band I was in. And then he moved away and we kind of kept in contact. And over the last few years we've gotten together at a lot of Dixieland festivals and parties like this, and we do kind of classic swing material. And I guess we've recorded a lot and I've written out some arrangements for him, some basic charts. So I guess it is a cooperative venture. We both like old, weird music, so we're in good company.

MR: Was this music played in your house when you were a kid?

RK: You know oddly enough I don't think it was. My dad was a classical musician and he was the choir director at the church where we grew up in, that was the Unitarian Church in Waltham, Massachusetts, and he used to write choral music. Granted he did write a few arrangements for big bands in that area, but I don't recall hearing it. I think I discovered Billie Holiday and Ella Fitzgerald and Frank Sinatra in high school somehow. And that's another thing. Times have changed so much. I remember spending many, many hours in used record stores trying to find this old music. It was so hard to find. And when you had found an old Ella Fitzgerald record it was like striking gold. And nowadays, everything is reissued and it's at our fingertips. It's such a different era. That's a digression from your question. But I just thought of that.

MR: Well sometimes it seems to make it more valuable when you have to go search it out. And when you finally get it, by God, you're going to listen to that record.

RK: Yeah. And wear it out. I have many old LPs but now I'm replacing them with CDs because they're more convenient.

MR: And you took up the guitar in high school?

RK: Yeah I actually took up the folk guitar. I wanted to play like Judy Collins and Joan Baez. And I taught myself how to play those three chords and stuff. And then I guess it was when I discovered the Billie Holiday stuff I was intrigued by that and I would go buy the sheet music and play the chords while I would sing along, for my own amusement. And that's where I took it.

MR: More than three chords in that music.

RK: Yeah a lot more. And it even made me take guitar lessons. I took a year of jazz guitar lessons in Boston and that's where I got the foundation for the chordal stuff that I do now.

MR: But your musical tastes have not been confined to just, say, the jazz world either, right?

RK: Well I do a little — from the jazz world I went into Western swing, because it's a logical step to go to Western swing which is a music originated by Bob Wills, a Texas fiddler in what the '30s I guess. And he combined Big Band and country music and it really worked. He used a fiddle section and horns and would take country songs and give them

the swing beat and it was very popular. So that was a very logical thing to do, to get into that music. And I was in a really fun big band that emulated that Bob Wills style. The band was called Ranch Dressing. And that was in Portland.

MR: That's a great name, by the way. I love that name.

RK: It was a great name. It was a lot of fun. But it was one of those bands that, you know, it's hard to get thirteen people together in the same place at the same time to rehearse or do gigs. So it was popular but short-lived. And then from that I was in a band called Beckaroo, which was a smaller band so it had maybe a better chance of rehearsing and stuff, but even that petered out eventually. And that was a little later. That was kind of 60s country, so it was some electric instruments and pedal steel and electric guitar, and the music of George Jones and Tammy Wynette and Loretta Lynn, stuff like that. I love that.

MR: Was that like a bar band?

RK: Yeah. Smoky bars, which is not very appealing. So I actually put that aside, and now my only venture into country is that I play in a duo, soon to be a trio, called Cactus Set Up, which is me playing guitar, and a fiddle player playing fiddle. And we do cowboy songs and some of that Western swing that I learned, and these Texas fiddle tunes. So that's another kind of digression.

MR: Do you do y our own promotion and all that?

RK: Pretty much but I'm not very good at it. It's very hard if you're insecure to kind of try to sell yourself. So I just try to work on the music and hope that things sell themselves. And I've been extremely lucky in my relationship with Dave Frishberg, he was an Arbors recording artist and he got me on the Arbors label and then I got to know Dan Barrett and Dan Barrett I think was instrumental in getting me on my first jazz party which was the Triangle Jazz Party in Tennessee. And then from that, you know this, and so it's kind of snowballed, which is great, because I don't like to make those cold calls. Torture.

MR: "Hi you don't know me but I sing pretty good." Yeah that's tough. Click. Speaking of Arbors, I want to get this on tape here, from *Jazz Times* talking about your album with Dave, and this particular fellow says, "Kilgore sings with a happy voice filled of erudition and charm, turning every number into a sweet explication of the American song."

RK: Wow.

MR: Not bad, huh?

RK: What does erudition mean?

MR: I wish I knew. I wish I knew how to pronounce it. "Displays on disc the camaraderie of her gigs with Dave Frishberg at the piano."

RK: That's nice.

MR: That's nice.

RK: Yeah that's interesting because I really don't in some ways consider myself a jazz singer. Of course that's a very controversial tag. You know, who knows what that means? I don't improvises all that much and I stick pretty close to the melody, but I'm not like a show singer. I don't belt it out. So I'm somewhere in another world.

MR: Best to be a good singer I guess. I mean Nancy Wilson doesn't think of herself as a jazz singer either.

RK: Really? Wow.

MR: In fact she doesn't like it when you call her that. She says "I'm a singer." And whatever she chooses to do, she tries to do it well.

RK: Well I try to be a good singer.

MR: Let me play something here.

[audio interlude]

MR: Did this tune take a while to get a handle on?

RK: Yes, it's very hard. But I've always loved it instrumentally. It's a tune called "The Duke" by Dave Brubeck. And I've just always loved it instrumentally. And then I found out that it had words. So yeah, I had to sing it, because I liked it so much. And so I did my best. It's tough.

MR: Nice, real nice. I like the picture with the old time microphone.

RK: Yeah. That picture on that cover was — the actual sheet music for "I Saw Stars" looks just like that, but we stuck my picture in the little frame there.

MR: In this one I was going to ask you how many jumps did it take before they got the —

RK: Well let's see, I'm trying to think, probably about fifteen or twenty.

MR: Was this in front of one of those photographer's things?

RK: It was in front of a backdrop. And that whole pose was an afterthought. I had gone into the photographer saying oh I want this with the wind and the scarf flowing in the background and I had all these poses to look carefree. And the photographer at the end of the session said, "Well why don't you just try jumping just for the fun of it?" So those were the ones that were used.

MR: Yeah. Sometimes you need someone to tell you what to do in those situations. When you go on a gig, are you the type of vocalist who can tell everybody your keys?

RK: Oh I should hope so. Because I have a very narrow range so there's not much room for error. We've got to do it in my key or we can't do it at all.

MR: Well when you say, "I hope so," I mean to you it's obvious. Of course you've got to know your keys. But not all vocalists do. They go "well it goes—" [humms] in there.

RK: I don't trust my ear. I wouldn't want to do it that way. And I tend to over-prepare. I'm kind of fastidious that way. I have — not at this jazz party I don't have charts — but at all my other gigs I bring charts and they're all written out.

MR: Excellent.

RK: So I have firm ideas of how I want to do it.

MR: Well I know as accompanying vocalists sometimes that piano players appreciate it I think. I for instance would have a heck of a time playing "Body and Soul" in F sharp or something, if that was your key. And some guys do it. I'm sure some of those guys can do it down there.

RK: Yeah, the poor piano bar players who have to accompany all singers doing all things in all keys, and in the jazz world you have to be sensitive to the fact that horn players don't like to play in sharp keys, so you don't want to come in with a song in the key of E for a saxophone player. That would be bad news. So you want to keep to the flat keys. Things like that that you learn over the years.

MR: You had an earlier job with computers to mention.

RK: And I still love computers. I don't program them anymore. I used to program them but I left those days behind, I just use them now. I was a business programmer in the Cobol language. I actually liked it a long time ago, but it's more fun to just use my Macintosh and use E-mail and all those fun programs.

MR: What's the music scene like in the Northeast where you live?

RK: I live in the Northwest.

MR: Northwest. Portland.

RK: It's actually really vibrant. There are a lot of musicians moving to Portland all the time which is great because the level of musicianship is very high and it's very exciting. And every few months we hear, you know, so-and-so moved to Portland from New York — oh gosh. And it's great. But it means that there is more competition for gigs. But then on the other hand this guy moved to Portland and he created gigs where there weren't any gigs before, so I guess that can be done. I hope it's a trend that more non-smoking environments are sponsoring jazz, like coffee houses. If we can get away from the smoky bar atmosphere I would love that.

MR: You had mentioned that swing dancing is making a revival. That would help the music a great deal.

RK: It sure would. In this one place I play in Portland, it's a renovated ballroom called The Crystal Ballroom, and it's non-smoking and it's all ages. So it's just got something for everyone. It's wonderful. And it's amazingly popular. They have music there six nights a week. It's great.

MR: Do you have definite career goals for yourself?

RK: No. I want to be able to sing the music that I love, this old music, and I have a stack that I want to learn. This is my goal in life is to learn all this music. And it seems like every time I take something off the top and learn it, more things go on the bottom, so I'll never run out of music that I want to learn. I keep unearthing gems from that era by listening to old records and I want to keep that music alive in some small way. That's my goal. But as far as my career, I just want to be able to continue to do that, and I consider myself very fortunate to play with great musicians like here this weekend. I can't hardly believe it. It's just an incredible dream. And record, and just continue doing what I'm doing. I feel very, very fortunate. And it's almost impossible to make a living doing what I'm doing.

MR: Words of wisdom I suppose for aspiring jazz singers. Has it helped you significantly that you play an instrument?

RK: Yes, I think it has. It's helped me in my homework for sure, because I think if you can play a chordal instrument like a guitar or a piano it can help you to learn the material and understand it. I'm always leery of singers who learn songs from other singers' recordings, just by ear. I mean I'm sure that's a valid way to do it, but I always like to know what the correct melody was as written. And I try to get the sheet music and know, from the source, what it was like. And so I think the guitar for me is a great tool to help me learn how the music — the inner workings of the music rather than just someone else's interpretation of it. So yeah, I would encourage any singer to play an instrument if possible.

MR: How long have you and Peter been together?

RK: About a year. We met about a year ago. We were both teaching at a music camp on Vashon Island in Washington State. He was teaching bluegrass banjo and I was teaching guitar and vocals I guess. He's trying to teach me bluegrass.

MR: Bluegrass, as a matter of fact, Cal Collins played a lot of bluegrass, and there's quite a few similarities I think in jazz — that a lot of it's improvised, the feel is somewhat different but the concept is not all that different.

RK: Oh yeah, and it's funny, any kind of music that you don't know much about, from a distance you think it all sounds alike. Like all Irish music sounds alike, or all Bluegrass music sounds alike. But then when you get into it, my gosh, it's not the case at all. We've started going to hear live Bluegrass and there's some great groups that are very exciting. So it's all in the ear of the beholder.

MR: This is always a hard question, but can you think of one of the worst gigs you ever had? I try this question every now and then and most people have blocked them from their mind.

RK: Well I can probably think of several but there was one where we were playing at a club at kind of an early hour and there was going to be — I don't know how this person got this gig, it was piano, bass, fiddle, me on guitar or something. And well first of all the bass

player arrived and laid down his bass and the neck broke off. And that was a disaster. And then he had to run home and get another bass. And we played and I remember the owner of the establishment asked us if we could stop early because they wanted to start the Karaoke. That was an insult.

MR: Good morale builder right there.

RK: And people weren't into the music at all. So that was one place where they should not have had our music at all. And then there was a gig with Dave Frishberg where they didn't have a regular piano they had an electronic keyboard and he didn't know how to use it and he kept playing with all these dials and getting all these weird sounds and we just never knew what was going to happen next. That was bizarre. I'm sure I could think of more, but—

MR: What's your next — do you have another recording project in mind?

RK: Yes. There's a local trio in Portland called Tall Jazz and they are made up of a vibes player, a drummer and a bass player and they all happen to be over six feet tall, so they call each other Tall Jazz. Cute. They're all over six-two. And they're extremely prolific. They're great musicians and great businessmen, which, it doesn't usually happen that way in combination. But I'm going to record something with them in 1998. And I just recorded with them a Christmas CD which will come out this December. And previous to that I just recorded another thing for Arbors with Dave Frishberg, Jackie Coon on flugelhorn and Eddie Erickson on guitar, and he and I do a few duets and he's just one of my favorite singers of all times. So that was a real treat. And that was something I proposed to Arbors and they went for it, I was glad.

MR: Working with a small record label, although they have a great reputation, do they pay you for the session, basically that's it?

RK: Yeah they pay you for the session and then you get to get a break on purchasing CDs.

MR: So you purchase your own CDs and then you're free to—

RK: Well I purchase them for my local gigs. They have distributors who stock the stores in our areas so I don't have to worry about that. But I can sell as many as I want on gigs and to friends and stuff. And so I can make a little profit on that which is nice.

MR: Yeah. It always sounds weird to people who have no idea how the music business works perhaps, that you have to buy your own CDs.

RK: Well I'm sure on big labels and big names it's not like that at all and you get an advance and you get to tour and all expenses paid. But with a small label that's not the case at all. Again, I consider myself fortunate to be on that label. They're very supportive and they really want to keep classic jazz alive. They're wonderful people, and I can't say enough about them.

MR: They throw a festival too, don't they?

RK: Yes, it's called The March of Jazz. It's every March in Clearwater Beach, Florida, and I've played it for the last two years and I'll be playing it next year. And it's going to be an international one next year. They're have musicians from all over the world. So that should be fun.

MR: Sounds like an interview trip to me.

RK: Yes.

MR: I know the Dombers pretty well. Nice people.

RK: Oh they're wonderful.

MR: Have you been able to record or perform with any of the real elderstatesmen in the jazz world?

RK: Record or perform?

MR: Yeah.

RK: Well with Bob Haggart. I consider him an elderstatesman for sure. I've performed several times, he's just a joy, so that's a real thrill. And Scott Hamilton, Dave McKenna, all these folks are great. They're not "elder" yet, but they will be.

MR: Yeah, and on the other hand it's nice to see Harry Allen and Jon-Erik [Kellso] coming in and doing this kind of music.

RK: Oh, I know, it's great.

MR: Hopefully there'll be an audience for it.

RK: Yeah, I hope so.

MR: Well I think you're doing your part. Peter, should I ask her any other — If we were to do this ten years from now, to do another interview —

RK: Let's see how old will I be. Okay. I might be an elderstatesman by then.

MR: Would it be elderstateswoman?

RK: Elderstatesperson. Gosh I hope that I'm able to keep doing all these things.

MR: Have you attempted to write your own tunes?

RK: I've made feeble attempts but they always kind of turn into tunes that have already been written. So I figure I guess they've all been written. And then I see new people coming out with new songs all the time. It's amazing to me.

MR: Do you hear anybody today that may be writing what would become standards twenty, thirty years from now?

RK: Well I think the closest to that is the songs that Dave Frishberg writes I think are very beautifully crafted and melodic and memorable. And Bob Dorough is another great writer. But gee, those are the only people that come to mind.

MR: Any pop artists – do you listen to any pop artists?

RK: No. Well Alison Krauss. She's in the bluegrass/pop vein. I think she's the greatest singer in the world alive today. I love her so much. She's about my favorite singer around.

MR: Well they certainly have you working this weekend, and singing at what, 9:30 AM or something. So I think you pulled it off pretty well, and I want to — on behalf of Hamilton College I want to thank you for joining us.

RK: Well thank you. I guess after enough arm twisting it was my pleasure. Maybe I'll visit the campus some day.

MR: That would be a pleasure, too. We're about five hours from New York.

RK: How far are you from here?

MR: About four and a half. So we're right in between. When you come you can sit and watch your interview.

RK: Or all these other ones too. These sound interesting. Well I'm glad that you're doing what you're doing, and I hope you get a lot more people.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.

RK: Thank you, Monk.